

Generic Degree Three in $J\mathcal{C}(3)$: Collision Geometry and Galois Group S_3

Chloe van der Vlugt

August 22, 2026

Abstract

We study possible counterexamples to the complex three-dimensional Jacobian conjecture. For a polynomial self-map $F: \mathbb{A}_{\mathbb{C}}^n \rightarrow \mathbb{A}_{\mathbb{C}}^n$, we consider the coordinate ring C_F of the scheme of pairs with the same image. Restriction to the diagonal has kernel $\text{Obs}(F)$, whose vanishing over $\mathbb{C}$ characterizes polynomial automorphisms. For a counterexample of generic degree three, we find that the residual factor of the generic collision algebra is the normal closure N of L/K , whose Galois group is S_3 .

Indeed, generic base change identifies $K \otimes_B C_F$ with $L \otimes_K L$. For a finite separable extension and a primitive generator α , the marked-root decomposition gives

$$L \otimes_K L \simeq_L L \times D_{\alpha},$$

with tensor multiplication equal to first projection. In degree three, D_{α} is split in the normal branch and is the normal closure in the nonnormal branch. A degree-three map is already nonautomorphic, so on this stratum the counterexample condition is equivalent to the Keller condition. Classical Galois rigidity excludes the normal branch and yields the stated S_3 -description. The marked-root decomposition itself is Keller-free. No existence assertion is made, and counterexamples of other generic degrees are not classified.

Licensed under [CC BY 4.0](#).

Contents

1	Introduction	2
2	General construction	3
2.1	The two ideals and their obstruction	3
2.2	The fiber-product interpretation	4
2.3	Generic fibers and marked-root decomposition	5
2.4	Automorphism detection	7
3	The cubic S_3 obstruction in dimension three	8
3.1	The cubic extension and its normal closure	8
3.2	The cubic residual factor	11
4	Further directions	13

1 Introduction

The complex Jacobian conjecture $JC(n)$ asks whether every polynomial self-map

$$F: \mathbb{A}_{\mathbb{C}}^n \longrightarrow \mathbb{A}_{\mathbb{C}}^n, \quad \det JF \in \mathbb{C}^\times,$$

is a polynomial automorphism. The Jacobian condition makes F étale; the conjecture asks whether this local condition forces global invertibility. We make the global obstruction visible through the self-fiber product

$$R_F := \mathbb{A}_{\mathbb{C}}^n \times_{\mathbb{A}_{\mathbb{C}}^n} \mathbb{A}_{\mathbb{C}}^n,$$

where both maps to the target are F . Its points record equal-image pairs, and it contains the diagonal Δ as a canonical closed subscheme. If C_F is the coordinate ring of R_F , restriction to Δ defines a map $\bar{\mu}_F$ with kernel $\text{Obs}(F)$. Over $\mathbb{C}$,

$$\text{Obs}(F) = 0 \iff R_F = \Delta \iff F \text{ is a polynomial automorphism.}$$

A possible counterexample must therefore remain globally noninvertible despite being étale. We organize this failure by generic degree. Put

$$B = \mathbb{C}[F_1, \dots, F_n], \quad K = \text{Frac}(B), \quad L = \mathbb{C}(x_1, \dots, x_n).$$

For a Keller map, L/K is finite separable and $[L : K]$ is the generic degree. Classical Galois rigidity makes such a map an automorphism whenever L/K is normal. Degree one is trivial, while every separable quadratic extension is normal, so generic degree three is the first possible degree of a counterexample.

This paper studies that first degree in dimension three. Since polynomial automorphisms have generic degree one, every map with $[L : K] = 3$ is already nonautomorphic. On this stratum,

$$F \text{ is a counterexample to } JC(3) \iff F \text{ is Keller.}$$

The construction behind the cubic dichotomy is independent of the Keller condition. Generic base change identifies the collision algebra with $L \otimes_K L$. If α is a primitive generator and $m_\alpha(T) = (T - \alpha)h_\alpha(T)$ over L , then separability gives

$$K \otimes_B C_F \simeq_K L \otimes_K L \simeq_L L \times D_\alpha, \quad D_\alpha = L[T]/(h_\alpha),$$

with tensor multiplication equal to projection onto the first factor. The first factor is the diagonal; D_α records the remaining generic collisions.

In degree three, D_α has rank two over L . It is split exactly when L/K is normal and is a field when L/K is nonnormal. On the Keller locus, Galois rigidity excludes the normal branch. In the remaining branch, D_α is the normal closure N of L/K , and

$$K \otimes_B C_F \simeq L \times N, \quad \text{Gal}(N/K) \simeq S_3.$$

Thus the S_3 -structure is forced by the residual collision algebra; it is not imposed at the outset. This is a conditional description of the generic-degree-three locus: it neither asserts that the locus is nonempty nor classifies counterexamples of other generic degrees.

Section 2 develops the dimension-independent collision obstruction, generic base change, marked-root decomposition, and automorphism criterion. Section 3 specializes these constructions to cubic extensions. Section 4 isolates the normalization and boundary questions leading to the planar sequel. The closing low-degree corollary records the precise handoff to that paper.

2 General construction

The organizing question is how the failure of a polynomial self-map to be one-to-one is encoded by the part of its fiber square lying off the diagonal. The collision ideal isolates that part scheme-theoretically; generic base change then identifies its field-level factors with conjugate embeddings. All constructions in this section are dimension-independent.

2.1 The two ideals and their obstruction

Throughout the paper, the base field is $\mathbb{C}$. Let

$$F = (F_1, \dots, F_n): X = \mathbb{A}_{\mathbb{C}}^n \longrightarrow \mathbb{A}_{\mathbb{C}}^n$$

be a polynomial map, and let

$$S = \mathbb{C}[x_1, \dots, x_n, y_1, \dots, y_n].$$

The map F is Keller if

$$\det JF \in \mathbb{C}^\times.$$

Define

$$I_R(F) = (F_i(x) - F_i(y))_{i=1}^n, \quad I_\Delta = (x_i - y_i)_{i=1}^n, \quad \text{Obs}(F) := I_\Delta / I_R(F).$$

The quotient $\text{Obs}(F)$ is naturally an ideal of the collision ring $C_F := S / I_R(F)$; we call it the obstruction ideal. For a fixed map F , we abbreviate $I_R(F)$ to I_R .

Proposition 2.1 (Canonical containment). *For every polynomial map F ,*

$$I_R(F) \subseteq I_\Delta.$$

Proof. For $H \in \mathbb{C}[x_1, \dots, x_n]$, the difference $H(x) - H(y)$ belongs to $(x_1 - y_1, \dots, x_n - y_n)$. This follows by induction on H , or by telescoping each monomial one coordinate at a time. Apply the statement to each coordinate F_i . $\square$

Let $A := \mathbb{C}[x_1, \dots, x_n]$. Diagonal evaluation induces a surjective ring map

$$\bar{\mu}_F: C_F \longrightarrow A, \quad [s]_{I_R} \longmapsto s(x, x).$$

Proposition 2.2 (The diagonal kernel). *As ideals of C_F ,*

$$\ker(\bar{\mu}_F) = \text{Obs}(F) = I_\Delta / I_R.$$

Consequently,

$$\ker(\bar{\mu}_F) = 0 \iff \text{Obs}(F) = 0 \iff I_R = I_\Delta.$$

Proof. The kernel of diagonal evaluation $S \rightarrow A$ is I_Δ . Passing through S / I_R therefore identifies the displayed kernel with I_Δ / I_R . Since $I_R \subseteq I_\Delta$,

$$I_\Delta / I_R = 0 \iff I_R = I_\Delta.$$

$\square$

2.2 The fiber-product interpretation

Let

$$A = \mathbb{C}[x_1, \dots, x_n], \quad B = \mathbb{C}[F_1, \dots, F_n] \subseteq A.$$

Let $X = \operatorname{Spec} A$, let $Y = \operatorname{Spec} B$, and let

$$f_F: X \longrightarrow Y$$

be the morphism induced by $B \hookrightarrow A$. The homomorphisms $\iota_x, \iota_y: A \rightrightarrows C_F$, defined by $\iota_x(a) = [a(x)]$ and $\iota_y(a) = [a(y)]$, agree on B because $[F_i(x)] = [F_i(y)]$ in C_F . Their common restriction equips C_F with a B -algebra structure.

Theorem 2.3 (Fiber-product interpretation). *There is a canonical B -algebra equivalence and its dual affine-scheme equivalence*

$$C_F \cong A \otimes_B A, \quad R_F := \operatorname{Spec} C_F \cong X \times_Y X.$$

Under the first equivalence, $\bar{\mu}_F$ is tensor multiplication

$$A \otimes_B A \longrightarrow A, \quad a \otimes a' \longmapsto aa'.$$

Its dual morphism is the diagonal

$$\Delta_{X/Y}: X \longrightarrow X \times_Y X.$$

Proof. A map $C_F \rightarrow T$ to a commutative $\mathbb{C}$ -algebra T is equivalent to a pair of maps $f, g: A \rightrightarrows T$ satisfying

$$f(F_i) = g(F_i) \quad (1 \leq i \leq n).$$

Since the F_i generate B , this is precisely the universal property of $A \otimes_B A$. Applying Spec to this equivalence and using

$$\operatorname{Spec}(A \otimes_B A) \cong \operatorname{Spec} A \times_{\operatorname{Spec} B} \operatorname{Spec} A$$

gives the asserted fiber-product equivalence. The statements about multiplication and the diagonal follow on pure tensors. $\square$

On complex points,

$$R_F(\mathbb{C}) = \{(u, v) : F(u) = F(v)\}.$$

Inside $X \times X = \operatorname{Spec} S$, the ideals I_R and I_Δ define $X \times_Y X$ and its diagonal. Thus

$$I_R = I_\Delta \iff X \times_Y X = \Delta_{X/Y}(X)$$

as closed subschemes. This is the geometric form of obstruction vanishing.

2.3 Generic fibers and marked-root decomposition

Let F be a polynomial self-map, and let

$$A = \mathbb{C}[x_1, \dots, x_n], \quad B = \mathbb{C}[F_1, \dots, F_n] \subseteq A.$$

Let

$$K = \text{Frac}(B), \quad L = \text{Frac}(A).$$

Proposition 2.4 (Keller generic geometry). *If F is Keller, then its coordinate functions are algebraically independent, the morphism*

$$f_F: \text{Spec } A \longrightarrow \text{Spec } B$$

is étale and quasi-finite, and L/K is a finite separable extension. Consequently, every Keller map, and in particular every complex Jacobian-conjecture counterexample, has a finite separable generic field extension.

Proof. The identity

$$dF_1 \wedge \dots \wedge dF_n = \det(JF) dx_1 \wedge \dots \wedge dx_n \neq 0$$

gives algebraic independence, so $B \cong \mathbb{C}[u_1, \dots, u_n]$. As a B -algebra, A has the presentation

$$A \cong \mathbb{C}[u_1, \dots, u_n, X_1, \dots, X_n] / (F_i(X) - u_i)_{i=1}^n.$$

Its relative Jacobian determinant is the unit $\det(JF)$. The Jacobian criterion therefore makes f_F étale, hence quasi-finite. Since $B \subseteq A$, the morphism is dominant, so quasi-finiteness gives $[L : K] < \infty$. Its generic point is étale, and therefore L/K is separable. $\square$

For the remainder of this subsection, assume that F is dominant and generically finite. Let

$$\theta: K \otimes_B A \longrightarrow L, \quad \lambda \otimes a \longmapsto \lambda a.$$

Theorem 2.5 (Generic collision bridge). *The map θ is an isomorphism. Consequently, there is a K -algebra isomorphism*

$$K \otimes_B C_F \cong L \otimes_K L,$$

and the following square commutes:

$$\begin{array}{ccc} K \otimes_B C_F & \xrightarrow{1 \otimes \bar{\mu}_F} & K \otimes_B A \\ \sim \downarrow & & \downarrow \theta \sim \\ L \otimes_K L & \xrightarrow{\mu_L} & L. \end{array}$$

Proof. Let $U = B \setminus \{0\}$. Since $K = U^{-1}B$, localization gives

$$K \otimes_B A \xrightarrow{\sim} U^{-1}A, \quad \frac{b}{u} \otimes a \longmapsto \frac{ba}{u}.$$

Since $A = \mathbb{C}[x_1, \dots, x_n]$ is a domain and $B \subseteq A$,

$$B \setminus \{0\} \subseteq A \setminus \{0\}.$$

Hence

$$U^{-1}A \hookrightarrow \text{Frac}(A) = L, \quad \frac{a}{u} \mapsto \frac{a}{u}.$$

Composing this injection with the displayed isomorphism gives θ , so θ is injective.

Since F is generically finite, L/K is a finite extension. The image of $U^{-1}A$ in L is

$$K[x_1, \dots, x_n].$$

Since each x_i is algebraic over K , this K -domain is finite-dimensional over K , hence is a field. Since it contains A , it contains $\text{Frac}(A) = L$; the reverse inclusion is already given by its embedding into L . Therefore

$$U^{-1}A = L,$$

and θ is an isomorphism.

By Theorem 2.3, identify C_F with $A \otimes_B A$. There is a K -algebra isomorphism

$$\beta: K \otimes_B (A \otimes_B A) \xrightarrow{\sim} (K \otimes_B A) \otimes_K (K \otimes_B A)$$

defined on pure tensors by

$$\beta(\lambda \otimes (a \otimes a')) = (\lambda \otimes a) \otimes (1 \otimes a').$$

Its inverse is

$$(\lambda \otimes a) \otimes (\lambda' \otimes a') \mapsto \lambda \lambda' \otimes (a \otimes a').$$

The balancing relations over B and K show that these formulas are well-defined, and the two displayed maps are mutually inverse. Composing β with $\theta \otimes_K \theta$ gives

$$\Phi_F: K \otimes_B C_F \xrightarrow{\sim} L \otimes_K L.$$

It remains to identify the diagonal map. Under $C_F \cong A \otimes_B A$, the homomorphism $\bar{\mu}_F$ is multiplication. Therefore, on a pure tensor,

$$\begin{aligned} (\mu_L \circ \Phi_F)(\lambda \otimes (a \otimes a')) &= (\lambda a) a' = \lambda a a', \\ (\theta \circ (1 \otimes \bar{\mu}_F))(\lambda \otimes (a \otimes a')) &= \theta(\lambda \otimes a a') = \lambda a a'. \end{aligned}$$

Pure tensors generate $K \otimes_B C_F$, so the two homomorphisms are equal. This proves the commutative square. $\square$

Suppose now that L/K is separable and has a power basis $L = K(\alpha)$. Let $m_\alpha(T) \in K[T]$ be the minimal polynomial of α , and let $h_\alpha(T) \in L[T]$ be determined by

$$m_\alpha(T) = (T - \alpha)h_\alpha(T) \quad \text{in } L[T].$$

Theorem 2.6 (Marked-root tensor decomposition). *Give $L \otimes_K L$ its L -algebra structure through the left tensor factor. There is an L -algebra equivalence*

$$L \otimes_K L \cong L \times L[T]/(h_\alpha),$$

under which tensor multiplication $L \otimes_K L \rightarrow L$ is projection onto the first factor.

Proof. The power-basis presentation

$$L \cong K[T]/(m_\alpha)$$

and base change from K to L give an L -algebra isomorphism

$$L \otimes_K L \xrightarrow{\sim} L[T]/(m_\alpha), \quad 1 \otimes \alpha \mapsto T.$$

Since m_α is separable, $m'_\alpha(\alpha) \neq 0$. Differentiating

$$m_\alpha(T) = (T - \alpha)h_\alpha(T)$$

and evaluating at $T = \alpha$ gives

$$h_\alpha(\alpha) = m'_\alpha(\alpha) \neq 0.$$

Thus $T - \alpha$ does not divide h_α , so these two polynomials are coprime in $L[T]$. The Chinese remainder theorem now gives

$$L[T]/(m_\alpha) \xrightarrow{\sim} L[T]/(T - \alpha) \times L[T]/(h_\alpha) \xrightarrow{\sim} L \times L[T]/(h_\alpha).$$

Under the first isomorphism above, a pure tensor $\ell \otimes p(\alpha)$, with $p \in K[T]$, corresponds to the class of $\ell p(T)$. Tensor multiplication sends it to $\ell p(\alpha)$, which is evaluation at $T = \alpha$. Under the Chinese remainder isomorphism, this evaluation map is projection onto the factor $L[T]/(T - \alpha) \cong L$. Hence tensor multiplication is the first projection. $\square$

Together with Theorem 2.5, this gives

$$K \otimes_B C_F \cong L \times L[T]/(h_\alpha),$$

where the first projection is the generic diagonal.

2.4 Automorphism detection

Theorem 2.7 (Automorphism criterion). *For an arbitrary polynomial self-map $F: \mathbb{A}_{\mathbb{C}}^n \rightarrow \mathbb{A}_{\mathbb{C}}^n$, the following are equivalent:*

- (1) F is a polynomial automorphism;
- (2) F is injective on $\mathbb{A}^n(\mathbb{C})$;
- (3) $I_R(F) = I_\Delta$;
- (4) $\text{Obs}(F) = 0$.

Proof. Suppose first that F has polynomial inverse $G = (G_1, \dots, G_n)$. Then

$$x_i - y_i = G_i(F(x)) - G_i(F(y)) \in I_R$$

for every i , so $I_\Delta \subseteq I_R$. Proposition 2.1 gives equality. Thus (1) implies (3).

Suppose $I_R = I_\Delta$, and let $\text{ev}_{(a,b)}: S \rightarrow \mathbb{C}$ be evaluation at (a, b) . If $F(a) = F(b)$, then

$$I_R \subseteq \ker(\text{ev}_{(a,b)}).$$

Therefore $x_i - y_i \in I_\Delta = I_R$ gives $a_i - b_i = 0$ for every i . Thus $a = b$, proving (3) $\Rightarrow$ (2). The Ax–Grothendieck theorem [Ax69] gives (2) $\Rightarrow$ (1). Finally, Proposition 2.2 gives (3) $\iff$ (4). $\square$

Applied to Keller maps, Theorem 2.7 says that $JC(n)$ is equivalent to universal vanishing of $\text{Obs}(F)$, or equivalently to $I_R(F) = I_\Delta$.

We will also use the classical Galois case of the conjecture. It is the step that rules out the normal cubic branch under the Keller hypothesis.

Theorem 2.8 (Classical Galois rigidity). *Let*

$$F: \mathbb{A}_{\mathbb{C}}^n \longrightarrow \mathbb{A}_{\mathbb{C}}^n, \quad \det JF \in \mathbb{C}^\times,$$

and put

$$K = \mathbb{C}(F_1, \dots, F_n), \quad L = \mathbb{C}(x_1, \dots, x_n).$$

If L/K is normal, then F is a polynomial automorphism and $L = K$.

Proof. The Keller condition makes L/K finite and separable. Thus normality makes it Galois, and the conclusion is the classical Galois case of the Jacobian conjecture due to Campbell, with algebraic treatments by Razar and Wright [Cam73, Raz79, Wri81]. $\square$

Lean correspondence. `CollisionIdeals/General/Collision/CollisionDiagonal.lean`,
`CollisionIdeals/General/FiberProduct/Polynomial.lean`,
`CollisionIdeals/General/GenericFiber/CollisionDiagonal.lean`,
`CollisionIdeals/General/GenericFiber/MarkedRootDecomposition.lean`,
`CollisionIdeals/General/Keller/Interfaces.lean`, and
`CollisionIdeals/General/Automorphism/Equivalences.lean`. The Lean form of Theorem 2.5 takes surjectivity of θ as a parameter; the proof above derives it from generic finiteness. The predicates `KellerEtaleBridge` and `KellerFlatBridge` expose parts of Proposition 2.4 as theorem targets; Lean does not yet derive them, generic finiteness, or separability from `IsKeller`.

3 The cubic S_3 obstruction in dimension three

We now specialize the dimension-independent constructions of Section 2 to generic degree three. After the diagonal is exhibited as the first factor, the complementary generic collision algebra has degree two over L . For an arbitrary cubic map it is either split, corresponding to a normal cubic extension, or connected, corresponding to a nonnormal cubic extension. Degree three already rules out polynomial automorphy, so within this locus the counterexamples to $JC(3)$ are precisely the Keller maps. Classical Galois rigidity rules out the split branch on that counterexample locus. Its residual factor is therefore the normal closure, whose Galois group is S_3 .

Let $S_3 = \text{Perm}(\{1, 2, 3\})$ be the symmetric group on three letters.

3.1 The cubic extension and its normal closure

Let

$$F = (F_1, F_2, F_3): \mathbb{A}_{\mathbb{C}}^3 \longrightarrow \mathbb{A}_{\mathbb{C}}^3$$

be dominant and generically finite. Let

$$A = \mathbb{C}[x_1, x_2, x_3], \quad B = \mathbb{C}[F_1, F_2, F_3] \subseteq A, \quad K = \text{Frac}(B), \quad L = \text{Frac}(A),$$

and let

$$\theta: K \otimes_B A \longrightarrow L, \quad \lambda \otimes a \longmapsto \lambda a,$$

be the isomorphism of Theorem 2.5. Assume that F has generic degree three:

$$[L : K] = 3.$$

Because K has characteristic zero, L/K is separable. Choose a primitive element α [The26], so that $L = K(\alpha)$ with power basis $1, \alpha, \alpha^2$. If $m_\alpha \in K[T]$ is the minimal polynomial of α , let $h_\alpha \in L[T]$ be determined by

$$m_\alpha(T) = (T - \alpha)h_\alpha(T) \quad \text{in } L[T].$$

The marked-root decomposition identifies the algebra remaining after the diagonal factor with

$$D_\alpha := L[T]/(h_\alpha),$$

a finite L -algebra of degree two. Let N/K be the normal closure of L/K , containing L through the marked inclusion. Let

$$G = \text{Gal}(N/K), \quad H = \text{Gal}(N/L).$$

Restriction of automorphisms gives a bijection

$$G/H \xrightarrow{\sim} \text{Hom}_K(L, N), \quad gH \mapsto g|_L.$$

Because the conjugates of L generate its normal closure N , an element of G fixing every conjugate embedding fixes N . Hence the coset action is faithful and

$$\text{core}_G(H) = \bigcap_{g \in G} gHg^{-1} = 1.$$

The residual collision algebra detects which cubic branch occurs. We include the short argument in order to fix its marked identification with the normal closure.

Proposition 3.1 (Connected cubic residual factor). *The following conditions are equivalent:*

- (i) $\text{Spec } D_\alpha$ is connected;
- (ii) D_α is a field;
- (iii) h_α is irreducible over L ;
- (iv) L/K is nonnormal.

When they hold, there is an L -algebra isomorphism

$$\varphi: D_\alpha \xrightarrow{\sim}_L N.$$

Consequently,

$$\Psi: L \otimes_K L \xrightarrow{\sim}_L L \times N, \quad \text{pr}_1 \circ \Psi = \mu_L.$$

Proof. Write

$$m_\alpha(T) = T^3 + a_2T^2 + a_1T + a_0.$$

The quadratic h_α is separable. If it is irreducible, then D_α is a field and hence has connected spectrum. If it is reducible, it is a product of two distinct linear factors; the Chinese remainder theorem then gives $D_\alpha \simeq L \times L$, whose spectrum is disconnected. This proves the equivalence of (i), (ii), and (iii).

If h_α is reducible, it has a root $\beta \in L$. Separability gives $\beta \neq \alpha$, and the third root is

$$\gamma = -a_2 - \alpha - \beta \in L.$$

Thus m_α would split over L . Since $L = K(\alpha)$, the extension L/K would then be the splitting field of the separable polynomial m_α , hence normal. Conversely, if L/K is normal, then m_α splits over L , so h_α is reducible. Hence (iii) and (iv) are equivalent.

Assume these equivalent conditions, and let β denote the image of T in D_α . This field contains the three roots

$$\alpha, \quad \beta, \quad -a_2 - \alpha - \beta$$

of m_α , and is generated over L by β . It is therefore the splitting field of m_α , which is the normal closure N of L/K . Choose the resulting L -algebra isomorphism

$$\varphi: D_\alpha \xrightarrow{\sim}_L N.$$

Let

$$\Phi_\alpha: L \otimes_K L \xrightarrow{\sim}_L L \times D_\alpha$$

be the marked-root decomposition of Theorem 2.6. It satisfies

$$\text{pr}_1 \circ \Phi_\alpha = \mu_L.$$

Composing its second factor with φ , let

$$\Psi = (\text{id}_L \times \varphi) \circ \Phi_\alpha.$$

Since $\text{id}_L \times \varphi$ leaves the first factor unchanged, $\text{pr}_1 \circ \Psi = \mu_L$. □

Corollary 3.2 (The generic-degree-three counterexample locus). *The map F is not a polynomial automorphism. Consequently,*

$$F \text{ is a counterexample to } JC(3) \iff F \text{ is Keller.}$$

When these equivalent conditions hold, L/K is nonnormal and $\text{Spec } D_\alpha$ is connected.

Proof. If F were a polynomial automorphism, its coordinate functions would generate A , so $B = A$ and $L = K$, contrary to $[L : K] = 3$. The displayed equivalence now follows from the definition of a counterexample to $JC(3)$.

Assume these conditions, so that F is Keller. If L/K were normal, Theorem 2.8 would give $L = K$, again contradicting $[L : K] = 3$. Proposition 3.1 now identifies nonnormality with connectedness of $\text{Spec } D_\alpha$. □

Theorem 3.3 (Galois group of the connected residual factor). *If $\text{Spec } D_\alpha$ is connected, then*

$$\text{Gal}(N/K) \cong S_3.$$

Proof. Proposition 3.1 identifies N with the degree-two field D_α over L . Hence

$$|H| = [N : L] = 2.$$

The normal-closure identities recalled above give

$$\text{core}_G(H) = 1, \quad [G : H] = [L : K] = 3.$$

Hence the action of G on the three cosets of H gives

$$\rho: G \longrightarrow \text{Perm}(G/H) \cong S_3, \quad \ker \rho = \text{core}_G(H) = 1.$$

Core-freeness therefore makes ρ injective, so

$$|G| \leq |S_3| = 6.$$

The index formula gives

$$|G| = [G : H]|H| = 3 \cdot 2 = 6.$$

Thus $|G| = 6$, and the injective homomorphism ρ is an isomorphism $G \cong S_3$. $\square$

3.2 The cubic residual factor

Retain the cubic data of Section 3.1 and suppose that F lies in the counterexample locus of Corollary 3.2. Equivalently, F is Keller; the same corollary shows that D_α is connected and L/K is nonnormal. Proposition 3.1 then identifies D_α with N . Thus

$$B = \mathbb{C}[F_1, F_2, F_3] \subseteq A = \mathbb{C}[x_1, x_2, x_3], \quad K = \text{Frac}(B) \subseteq L = \text{Frac}(A) = K(\alpha) \subseteq N,$$

where $[L : K] = 3$ and N/K is the normal closure. Let

$$\theta: K \otimes_B A \xrightarrow{\sim} L, \quad \lambda \otimes a \longmapsto \lambda a.$$

Corollary 3.4 (Generic cubic S_3 collision). *There is a K -algebra isomorphism*

$$\Psi_F: K \otimes_B C_F \xrightarrow{\sim}_K L \times N, \quad \text{pr}_1 \circ \Psi_F = \theta \circ (1 \otimes \bar{\mu}_F).$$

It satisfies

$$\Psi_F(\ker(\theta \circ (1 \otimes \bar{\mu}_F))) = 0 \times N, \quad \text{Gal}(N/K) \cong S_3.$$

If

$$C_{F,K} := K \otimes_B C_F, \quad J_{F,K} := \ker(\theta \circ (1 \otimes \bar{\mu}_F)),$$

then the intrinsic residual quotient of the generic collision algebra is

$$C_{F,K} / \text{Ann}_{C_{F,K}}(J_{F,K}) \simeq_K N.$$

Consequently,

$$\text{Obs}(F) \neq 0, \quad I_R \subsetneq I_\Delta, \quad F \notin \text{Aut}_{\text{poly}}(\mathbb{A}_{\mathbb{C}}^3).$$

Proof. Theorem 2.5 gives a K -algebra isomorphism

$$\Phi_F: K \otimes_B C_F \xrightarrow{\sim}_K L \otimes_K L$$

such that

$$\mu_L \circ \Phi_F = \theta \circ (1 \otimes \bar{\mu}_F).$$

Proposition 3.1 gives

$$\Psi: L \otimes_K L \xrightarrow{\sim}_L L \times N, \quad \text{pr}_1 \circ \Psi = \mu_L.$$

After restricting Ψ from L to K , let

$$\Psi_F = \Psi \circ \Phi_F.$$

It follows that

$$\text{pr}_1 \circ \Psi_F = \theta \circ (1 \otimes \bar{\mu}_F), \quad \Psi_F(\ker(\theta \circ (1 \otimes \bar{\mu}_F))) = 0 \times N \neq 0.$$

The annihilator of $0 \times N$ in $L \times N$ is $L \times 0$. Therefore Ψ_F , followed by the second projection, induces

$$C_{F,K} / \text{Ann}_{C_{F,K}}(J_{F,K}) \xrightarrow{\sim}_K N.$$

Suppose that the diagonal-evaluation homomorphism $\bar{\mu}_F: C_F \rightarrow A$ were injective. Since K is a localization of B , it is flat over B , so $1 \otimes \bar{\mu}_F$ would also be injective. Theorem 2.5 shows that θ is an isomorphism. Therefore $\theta \circ (1 \otimes \bar{\mu}_F)$ would be injective, contradicting the nonzero kernel $0 \times N$ above. Hence $\ker(\bar{\mu}_F) \neq 0$, and Proposition 2.2 gives $\text{Obs}(F) \neq 0$. Proposition 2.1 shows that $I_R \subseteq I_\Delta$ is strict.

Finally, Theorem 3.3 identifies $\text{Gal}(N/K)$ with S_3 . If F were a polynomial automorphism, Theorem 2.7 would give $\text{Obs}(F) = 0$, contrary to $\text{Obs}(F) \neq 0$. $\square$

Remark (Ordered roots). Let

$$m_\alpha(T) = T^3 + a_2T^2 + a_1T + a_0$$

have roots $\alpha_1, \alpha_2, \alpha_3$ in N . For distinct i, j, k ,

$$\alpha_k = -a_2 - \alpha_i - \alpha_j, \quad K(\alpha_i, \alpha_j) = K(\alpha_1, \alpha_2, \alpha_3) = N.$$

Thus the residual factor, which marks two distinct roots, is already the ordered-root normal closure.

Lean correspondence. `CollisionIdeals/ComplexThree/Cubic/GaloisGroup.lean`, `CollisionIdeals/ComplexThree/Cubic/S3Collision.lean`, `CollisionIdeals/ComplexThree/Cubic/Main.lean`, and `CollisionIdeals/ComplexThree/Statements/JacobianConjecture.lean`. The generic product-annihilator quotient is formalized in `CollisionIdeals/General/GenericFiber/DiagonalObstruction.lean`. The Lean cubic witness takes the residual-field isomorphism and $H \neq 1$ as explicit inputs. It proves obstruction nonvanishing before using the Keller hypothesis solely to assemble the counterexample statement; the exact generic-degree-three equivalence displayed above is not yet packaged as a separate Lean theorem. In the manuscript the two field-theoretic inputs follow from Proposition 3.1 and Corollary 3.2; the use of classical Galois rigidity in that corollary is not yet formalized. Hidden inertia is formalized separately in `CollisionIdeals/ComplexThree/Cubic/HiddenInertia.lean`, so the cubic core has no normalization or ramification dependency.

Remark (Exact relation with classical complex $JC(3)$). The traditional complex three-dimensional Jacobian conjecture asserts that every polynomial map

$$F: \mathbb{A}_{\mathbb{C}}^3 \longrightarrow \mathbb{A}_{\mathbb{C}}^3, \quad \det JF \in \mathbb{C}^\times,$$

is a polynomial automorphism; equivalently, every such map satisfies $\text{Obs}(F) = 0$. In generic degree three, Corollary 3.2 instead gives

$$\begin{aligned} [L : K] = 3 &\implies \text{Obs}(F) \neq 0, & F \notin \text{Aut}_{\text{poly}}(\mathbb{A}_{\mathbb{C}}^3), \\ F \text{ is a counterexample to } JC(3) &\iff \det JF \in \mathbb{C}^\times, \\ F \text{ is a counterexample} &\implies \text{Spec } D_\alpha \text{ connected,} & \text{Gal}(N/K) \cong S_3. \end{aligned}$$

The first line is independent of the Keller condition. The additional content on the counterexample locus is that Theorem 2.8 excludes the normal cubic branch, after which the residual algebra itself produces the normal closure and its Galois group S_3 . Thus $JC(3)$ implies that the generic-degree-three counterexample locus is empty. This section does not construct such a map, and it does not assert that every possible counterexample to $JC(3)$ has generic degree three.

4 Further directions

The normal closure also carries a dimension-independent boundary picture, although none of it is needed for the cubic collision theorem. Let L/K be finite separable, let N/K be its normal closure, and let Y be a normal integral model with function field K . Write

$$G = \text{Gal}(N/K), \quad H = \text{Gal}(N/L), \quad Z = \text{Norm}_N(Y) \longrightarrow \overline{X} = \text{Norm}_L(Y) \longrightarrow Y.$$

Suppose that a normal model X of L is an open subscheme of $\overline{X}$ over Y , and that $X \rightarrow Y$ is étale.

Proposition 4.1 (Hidden inertia on a conjugate sheet). *Let $E \in Z^{(1)}$ be ramified over Y , with divisorial valuation w_E , restriction $v = w_E|_K$, and inertia group I_E . Then some $g \in G$ satisfies*

$$e((g^{-1}w_E)|_{L/v}) = [I_E : I_E \cap gHg^{-1}] > 1.$$

For every such g , the center of $(g^{-1}w_E)|_L$ on $\overline{X}$ lies in $\overline{X} \setminus X$.

Proof. Because N is the normal closure of L/K , the action of G on G/H is faithful, so $\bigcap_{g \in G} gHg^{-1} = 1$. Since $I_E \neq 1$, it is not contained in every conjugate of H ; the usual inertia formula gives the displayed index for a suitable g . If the corresponding center belonged to X , the étale morphism $X \rightarrow Y$ would force its ramification index to be one, a contradiction. $\square$

On the generic-degree-three counterexample locus of Section 3, the cubic extension is necessarily nonnormal and $G \cong S_3$. Thus any divisorial ramification in the ordered-root normalization is detected on a conjugate sheet and forced into the deleted boundary. This statement is conditional on the existence of such a ramified divisor; the cubic collision theorem itself neither requires nor asserts it.

The cubic and planar problems use the same diagonal in opposite ways. Here generic degree three forces a nonzero residual factor beside it. In the planar sequel, the goal is to prove that the off-diagonal factor vanishes, so that the collision scheme consists only of the diagonal.

A sequel will develop this normalization picture for planar Keller maps: conjugate affine sheets, their boundary and fixed-locus ideals, and the secant–trace comparison. Its remaining Keller-specific input is a uniform landing theorem converting a finite secant–frame lattice into control of arbitrary boundary sections. Purity and finite-étale rigidity enter only after that boundary statement is established.

5 Conclusion

The collision ideal turns injectivity into a scheme-theoretic equality. The obstruction $\text{Obs}(F)$ is precisely the kernel of diagonal evaluation, and it vanishes exactly when the collision relation equals the diagonal. After passage to the generic fiber, that diagonal becomes the multiplication factor of $L \otimes_K L$, while the remaining factors record the other embeddings of L .

In generic degree three, the diagonal persists as the first factor beside a quadratic residual algebra, and nonautomorphy is automatic. Thus the counterexample condition is equivalent to the Keller condition. On this locus the classical Galois case rules out the split, normal branch; hence the residual algebra is connected, it is the normal closure N , its Galois group is S_3 , and

$$K \otimes_B C_F \simeq L \times N.$$

Its nonzero residual factor gives $\text{Obs}(F) \neq 0$. Hence every map in the generic-degree-three counterexample locus has the normal-closure factor N , with $\text{Gal}(N/K) \cong S_3$. The theorem does not assert that this locus is nonempty or classify counterexamples of other generic degrees. The normalization principle of Section 4 explains how the same conjugate sheet geometry leads to boundary questions, which are reserved for the planar sequel.

Motivating example. The explicit three-dimensional polynomial counterexample announced by Levent Alpöge [Alp26] and independently formalized in Isabelle/HOL by Ramos, Hulak, and de Queiroz [RHdQ26] motivated the cubic S_3 comparison. The formal verification establishes a constant nonzero Jacobian determinant and distinct rational points with the same image. That particular map is not used in the arguments above: the dimension-three result describes the structure of the generic-degree-three counterexample locus.

The formalization uses Lean 4 and Mathlib [dMU21, The20].

Corollary 5.1 (First possible generic degree). *If F is Keller and $[L : K] \leq 2$, then F is a polynomial automorphism. Consequently, every complex Jacobian-conjecture counterexample has generic degree at least three.*

Proof. Proposition 2.4 makes L/K finite and separable. In degree one it is trivial, and in degree two it is Galois. Theorem 2.8 applies in either case. $\square$

This low-degree boundary is the handoff to the planar sequel. Paper II asks for the stronger conclusion that every planar Keller map has generic degree one—equivalently, by Galois rigidity and the automorphism criterion, that its collision scheme collapses to the diagonal.

Acknowledgment. OpenAI Codex (GPT-5.6 Sol) assisted with Lean proof engineering, mathematical and bibliographic checking, and manuscript editing. The author reviewed and takes responsibility for all statements, proofs, citations, and formalization code.

References

- [Alp26] Levent Alpöge. Post announcing an explicit counterexample to the Jacobian conjecture. https://x.com/__alpoge__/status/2079028340955197566, 2026. X post, accessed July 27, 2026.
- [Ax69] James Ax. Injective endomorphisms of varieties and schemes. *Pacific Journal of Mathematics*, 31(1):1–7, 1969.
- [Cam73] L. Andrew Campbell. A condition for a polynomial map to be invertible. *Mathematische Annalen*, 205:243–248, 1973.
- [dMU21] Leonardo de Moura and Sebastian Ullrich. The Lean 4 theorem prover and programming language. In *Automated Deduction—CADE 28*, volume 12699 of *Lecture Notes in Computer Science*, pages 625–635. Springer, 2021.
- [Raz79] Michael J. Razar. Polynomial maps with constant Jacobian. *Israel Journal of Mathematics*, 32(2–3):97–106, 1979.
- [RHdQ26] Arthur Freitas Ramos, David Barros Hulak, and Ruy Jose Guerra Barretto de Queiroz. Formal verification of an explicit counterexample to the jacobian conjecture. https://isa-afp.org/entries/Jacobian_Counterexample.html, 2026. Archive of Formal Proofs, Isabelle/HOL formalization.
- [The20] The mathlib Community. The Lean mathematical library. In *Proceedings of the 9th ACM SIGPLAN International Conference on Certified Programs and Proofs*, pages 367–381. ACM, 2020.
- [The26] The Stacks Project Authors. Primitive elements. <https://stacks.math.columbia.edu/tag/030N>, 2026. Lemma 9.19.1, Tag 030N.
- [Wri81] David Wright. On the Jacobian conjecture. *Illinois Journal of Mathematics*, 25(3):423–440, 1981.